

Speak, talk, say, and tell

Teaching guide

Choose a verb that fits the message and listener.

Understand the distinction

Say focuses on the words or message: She said hello; she said that she was busy. Tell commonly names the listener directly: She told me that she was busy. Use say something to someone, not say someone something.

Speak and talk often overlap for conversation. Speak is common with languages: speak Arabic. Talk about introduces a topic. Learn common exceptions as phrases: tell a story, tell the truth, speak to someone, talk to or with someone.

Compare the patterns

MESSAGE

She said the meeting was canceled.

The focus is the message.

LISTENER

She told me the meeting was canceled.

Me identifies the listener.

TOPIC

We talked about the schedule.

About introduces the topic.

Read each example. Explain what the highlighted choice means in context. Then cover the example and say a similar sentence.

Check your understanding

Write before looking at the answers. The guide gives a model answer and explains the choice. Other wording can be correct.

1. Correct this: She said me the answer.

2. Complete: Do you ___ Korean?

3. Does tell always need a listener?

Use it in your own life

Report a short message and identify who received it.

Self-check

Does your sentence express your intended meaning? Does its form follow the relevant pattern? Can a reader understand the context?

Try again

After checking the explanation, revise your sentence. Say it aloud or use it in a short conversation.

Answers and explanation

1. She told me the answer.

Alternatively: She said the answer to me.

2. speak

Speak is the usual verb for language ability.

3. No. Common phrases include tell a story and tell the truth.

Learn the whole phrase with its meaning.

One possible response

My colleague told me that the room had changed.

This is a model, not the only acceptable answer. Assess meaning, grammar, and context together.

Continue learning

Web lesson and related topics: englishladder.com/grammar-concepts/concept-36.html

A practical teaching sequence

1. Notice (2 minutes)

Ask learners to explain the differences between the comparison examples before reading the rules. Use their answers to identify the point that needs attention.

2. Explain and check (4 minutes)

Read the short explanation together. Keep its qualifications: a common pattern is not necessarily a rule for every context. Ask learners to give a counterexample where the lesson mentions an exception.

3. Apply (5 minutes)

Report a short message and identify who received it.

Have learners work alone, then compare with a partner. Ask the partner to restate the intended meaning before suggesting a correction.

4. Review (3 minutes)

Use the answer explanations to review the three checks. Accept natural alternatives that preserve the intended meaning. Ask each learner to revise one sentence and identify the change.

Extension

Change the person, time, place, or purpose in a comparison example. Ask whether the original pattern still fits and why. Revisit one example in the next lesson.

Feedback criteria

Meaning: the message is understandable. Form: the target pattern fits the context. Transfer: the learner can use it in a fresh example. This short activity is not a proficiency certification.